

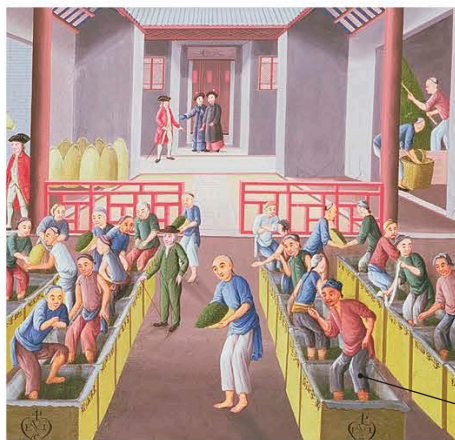
Qing China

The Qing Dynasty was the last dynasty of imperial China. It was established by the Manchu people from the modern-day region of Manchuria. In 1644, generals of the Ming dynasty asked for Manchu support to crush rebels. After defeating the rebels, the Manchu took power for themselves, occupying Beijing and establishing a new dynasty. Under Qing rule, the empire grew in strength and tripled in size.

The Manchus made up only a small percent of the entire Chinese population, so in order to rule peacefully they kept the Ming style of government but filled key posts with Manchu officials. Three remarkable emperors—Kangxi, Yongzheng, and Qianlong—ruled over a period of 134 years between 1661 and 1796. They extended Qing rule over modern-day Mongolia and much of Central Asia, and established political control over

present-day Southeast Asia. These rulers also provided stability and prosperity at home.

Highly successful at first, the Qing gradually lost power during the 19th century. The empire was forced to make compromises with foreign nations, lost a war against Japan in 1895, and was rocked by two major uprisings. Eventually, revolution broke out in China and the Qing Dynasty was overthrown in 1911.



◀ COMMERCIAL SUCCESS

In the 18th century, imperial China enjoyed a booming economy. The kingdom was at peace, and its population doubled to around 300 million. It exported tea, cotton, silk, porcelain, and furniture to Southeast Asia and Europe.

Chinese workers processing tea leaves in a factory



EMPEROR QIANLONG

The rule of Qianlong (reigned 1735–1796) was one of the longest in Chinese history.

A successful military leader, he expanded the empire west into what is now Xinjiang. He was also a writer and published over 40,000 poems.



FACT

Almost all the tea in the world was grown in China until British colonizers first brought tea to the hills of northern India in the 1830s.



◀ ARTS AND CRAFTS

Under the Qing, arts such as painting and calligraphy flourished, while Chinese craftsmanship reached new peaks. Emperor Kangxi ordered the publication of a dictionary, while Emperor Qianlong sponsored a library of Chinese writings. The Qing also produced beautiful examples of porcelain and glassware.

◀ FOREIGN INFLUENCE

The Qing lost a war with the British army in 1842, which forced them to hand Hong Kong Island to Britain and open up their ports to foreign traders. After another war in 1856, more ports were opened. Foreign traders were allowed to travel throughout China, bringing the whole country under increasing influence from the West.